



Acing the field: Legendary Indian shooting coach and multiple Asian Games gold medallist Jaspal Rana won the Coach of the Year award at the Sportstar Aces Awards in 2025.

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fourth-highest civilian honour.

Jaspal holds the record as India's most decorated Commonwealth Games athlete, with a tally of 15 medals, nine gold, four silver and two bronze, won across four editions. However, more than these medals, there was that one win in 1994 that mattered to him. At the Junior World Championships in Milan, painful boils had erupted across Jaspal's knee, making even the simple act of standing an immense ordeal. Doctors advised caution, and common sense demanded rest. Jaspal chose neither and ran away from the hospital. He didn't even take the prescribed tablets lest they mess up his doping samples.

Gritting his teeth through the pain, he stepped onto the firing line the next day and produced a performance for the ages, winning gold and equalling the junior world record.

Long before the legend came an almost irrational refusal to be beaten.

In the years that followed, our conversations became more frequent. At one point, inadvertently, he had become my coach too, teaching me technicalities no textbook would, so that I could understand and, in turn, cover the sport better.

The topic of the 1994 Junior Worlds inevitably came up during one of these chats. He brushed it aside with characteristic modesty, saying, "If you really want to look at model shooters, look at Abhinav Bindra, Gagan Narang. All extremely



Shooting star: Jaspal Rana was conferred the Padma Shri in 1997 at the age of 21 for his exceptional contributions to Indian shooting.

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